But 15 years on, the Maoist movement, once a potent force led by committed and educated leaders hailing mostly from Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, is teetering on the brink of collapse. While the CPI (Maoist) politburo has shrunk with the arrest of key figures like Prashant Bose, a.k.a. Kishan Da, in 2021 and Pramod Mishra in 2023 besides the killing of Katakam Sudarshan in 2023, the Central Committee, too, has dwindled from the 32 members it had in 2004. Of its 19 remaining members, 14 are from the two Telugu states, aged between 65 and 75, grappling with age and health issues. The next generation of leaders, less grounded in doctrine, are little more than gun-toting combatants like Hidma.

The Union and state governments have ramped up operations, combining military precision with developmental initiatives to address the root causes of insurgency. At a recent strategy session in Hyderabad, intelligence officials from seven states—Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Telangana and Odisha—pored over Maoist documents to devise counter-insurgency measures for 38 LWE-affected districts. They emphasised the urgent need to boost education and healthcare in these regions, ensuring that the socio-economic inequities that fuel extremism are addressed.

Police sources in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh note that the ageing Maoist leadership is increasingly incapable of countering the modern tactics employed by security forces. "The odd IED attack may still make headlines, but it no longer galvanises support. Even their sympathisers know the end is near," remarked one officer on the condition of anonymity. The Union ministry of home affairs has set an ambitious target: to relegate the entire chapter of Maoist militancy to history by March 2026. With the death of Chalapati and the steady erosion of the Maoist leadership, that goal may be well within reach. ■



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MAHAKUMBH STAMPEDE

A TRAGEDY FORETOLD

By Avaneesh Mishra

On the eve of Mauni Amavasya, a day of silent communion with the gods, millions had gathered on the banks of the Sangam under the ink-black sky. The gods are said to descend here on this day, and a holy dip at the confluence of the Ganga, Yamuna and the elusive Saraswati is considered especially auspicious. A multitude had staked their place near the water, waiting for the *brahma muhurta*, the sacred hour before dawn, to be the first to take a *snan* (holy bath) and wash away a lifetime of sins. Some had been there for hours, others for days, wrapped in woollen shawls and thin blankets, whispering mantras, their breath rising in white, ghostly puffs in the cold January air. Some eventually curled up in sleep, others continued to kneel in silent prayer.

It was past midnight. No one noticed the first ripple of movement. Nor perhaps the next. But then a tide of humanity surged forward, and the barricades, rendered flimsy under the weight of faith, collapsed. Those resting on the ground were swallowed